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Contingency Theory of Leadership

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Contingency Theory of Leadership by Fiedler

•Fiedler's Contingency theory of leadership holds that people become leaders not only because of their qualities but also because of various situational factors and the interactions between group members and the leader.

- This model also explains a relationship between **leadership style** and the favorableness of a situation.
- Fiedler described situational favorableness in terms of 3 dimensions;

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- the leader and member relationship,
- the degree of task structure, and
- the leader’s position power.
- If the three dimensions are high, the situation can be said to be favorable. If the three dimensions are low, the situation in combination with leadership style determines effectiveness.
- Human relations-oriented manager/leader is effective in the intermediate range of favorableness.
- In the very favorable and very unfavorable situation, task-oriented leadership is effective.

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- This theory is criticized for its deficiencies like a narrow focus on a single leader trait (task or relations orientations), ambiguity in a measurement of terms of the model, and lack of explanatory process.
- Fiedler proposed a new theory based on empirical research, which is called the cognitive resource theory.
- He identified the situations under which the leader's cognitive resources namely intelligence, experience, and technical expertise contribute to group performance.

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Contingency Theory of Leadership

by Fiedler

Leadership Style Least Preferred Co-worker

Situational Favorableness

Matching Leadership Styles to Situations

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Advantages

1. Flexibility of Management Style
2. Employee Opinions Matter
3. Flexibility in Task Structure
4. Anyone Can Become a Leader

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Flexibility of Management Style

- Fiedler discovered that different management styles worked best for different types of businesses based on factors such as the type of work, organizational structure, stress levels and how readily change was accepted.
- Through Fiedler's contingency theory, businesses are able to better assess and tailor their management to specific organizational needs.

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Employee Opinions Matter

- Under Fiedler's contingency theory, a leader's effectiveness is directly dependent on her relationship with her employees.
- To be successful, a leader must fit into the overall culture of the organization.
- The leader must also have the respect of her employees and be perceived as able to handle the responsibilities of a leadership role.
- As a result, leaders mold themselves to the organization and don't try to force the organizational culture to bend to them.

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Flexibility in Task Structure

- Different types of tasks require different structural levels.
- Fiedler's contingency theory takes this into consideration by allowing for flexibility in task structure.
- creative occupations such as those with artists or software developers, require less structuring and more freedom to explore creativity.

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Anyone Can Become a Leader

- While some people believe leaders are born, Fiedler's contingency theory proposes that anyone can become a leader in the right situation.
- Leaders must try to find their niche to excel
- leaders with poor interpersonal skills will fare better being matched with businesses that have highly structured environments.

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Thank you

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Aglaia
connecting you